2022 assembly polls, the Kuki National Organisation or KNO, an umbrella group of 17 insurgent groups, and UPF, which represents eight other Kuki outfits, had publicly extended support to all BJP candidates in Kuki areas.

The revelation has led to deep resentment among Meitei groups, who had already been alleging that the Centre and armed forces were soft on Kuki militant groups party to the SoO. Though Sarma initially did not respond to Haokip's affidavit, a week later, he issued an official denial after several BJP legislators submitted a memorandum to the Union government demanding his clarification. But the damage was already done, as the Centre is being accused of dithering on revoking the SoO agreement with Kuki groups because of their previous political support.

On the other hand, Kuki civil society groups are increasingly getting suspicious of the BJP, accusing it of going soft on Biren and Meitei vigilante groups. Even the armed forces have alleged that women vigilante groups in the Imphal valley often block roads, restricting their movement and helping the rioters. On June 24, around 1,200 such women forced a convoy of the Indian army to release a dozen militants belonging to the Meitei separatist group Kanglei Yawol Kanna Lup (KYKL), which in 2015 had ambushed and killed 20 Indian soldiers. Sources in the army claim they cannot take effective action as the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, or AFSPA, is not in operation in most areas where violence is taking place. The Centre is unlikely to expand the AFSPA's scope as it could invite an outrage in the Imphal valley.

A few civil society groups representing Kukis, who are predominantly Christians, also allege that the BJP regime's Hindutva ideology is hindering effective intervention. Party leaders dismiss such assertions, though some admit in private that they can't be seen as being "harsh" on Meiteis, who are largely Hindus, especially ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. Thus, walking a tightrope, the BJP government is largely bordering on inactivity. In all this, peace has remained a casualty in Manipur. ■

RAJASTHAN

A PUZZLING PATCH-UP

By Rohit Parihar

It is an anti-climax for Sachin Pilot's supporters. In a surprise turn of events, the rebel Congress leader from Rajasthan has backed down from his long confrontation with his arch nemesis, chief minister Ashok Gehlot. Until as early as May, Pilot had charged up his supporters with his Ajmer-Jaipur yatra against the Gehlot regime. He had even threatened to launch a state-wide agitation if his demands were not met.

Cut to now. Pilot is a changed man. "Gehlot is trying to take everyone along," he said, just days after Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, senior leader Rahul Gandhi and general secretary K.C. Venugopal held a meeting of about 30 leaders from Rajasthan in Delhi on July 6. Pilot also said, "Gehlot is elder to me both in experience and age"—exactly what he had told INDIA TODAY a week before his famous July 2020 revolt to pull down the Gehlot government. In the same breath, he had also described Gehlot as "my leader," expecting prominence in official publicity and a say in decisions as second in command to the chief minister.

How will it go this time? Earlier, he was prone to dressing up reported snubs in claims of having turned down offers such as executive president or general secretary in-charge of Gujarat elections, which his rivals would describe as bluffs. In a big departure from that tack, this time he said he would abide by whatever the party offers him. "It is good he has reposed faith in the high command to accept whatever task they assign him," Gehlot tells INDIA TODAY.

So, is there any quid pro quo? Insiders say an official role is unlikely for Pilot in Rajasthan, something he was categorically told by Sonia Gandhi after his failed revolt. But the Gujjar leader's camp hasn't lost hope. On the other hand, Gehlot's aides deny any conditional compromise or power-sharing formula. Also, there is little chance of Pilot having a say in government affairs. However, he will have some say in cabinet reshuffles, if any, besides getting the due share of his nominees in the ongoing organisational appointments.

The mellowing of Pilot has evoked mixed reactions. Gehlot is reportedly not keen to amplify his troubles with Pilot any further and is okay with the current position. He and the central party leadership are now left with the task of working out a strategy to put up a united face. That will help the Congress in the election year. A section of Pilot loyalists insists that in the bargain, he has ensured they will be rewarded with their due space in the organisation and ticket distribution.



"[ASHOK] GEHLOT IS TRYING TO TAKE EVERYONE ALONG... HE IS ELDER TO ME, BOTH IN EXPERIENCE AND AGE"

SACHIN PILOT
Rebel Congress leader